



Apple's combo speakers

Apple has patented a planned set of headphones that may automatically switch to a loudspeaker mode depending on position



World's biggest HDTV

Samsung is set to unveil the world's biggest UHDTV with an 85-inch screen, at the upcoming Consumer Electronics Show 2013

Bazaar

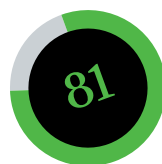
HP Spectre XT

Brilliant performance and sophisticated looks

We have tested some very well built ultrabooks, the Dell XPS 14 and the Samsung Series 9 being prime examples. The HP Spectre XT is cut from a similar cloth with its very good build quality. Its magnesium alloy frame lends it solidity, despite maintaining a slim form factor. The Spectre XT's lid has brushed metal finish, much like the Envy 4's, but in a lighter silver hue, which carries on throughout the ultrabook's surface. The lid hinge design is very similar too, but in the Spectre XT, the screen sits slightly higher with a distinct gap between its bottom lid and spine. Parallel layers of cooling vents on the XT's underside helps with ventilation. Ports are distributed on both sides, but there's no optical drive. The HP Spectre XT's build quality is pretty much on par with the best of the ultrabooks out there. And do keep in mind that the XPS 14 and the Series 9 are considerably more expensive than the Spectre XT.

The performance of the Spectre XT is truly astonishing, considering it is keeping up with the much more powerful (and more expensive) Series 9 rather easily. In the PC Mark Vantage test, the Spectre XT scores 12176 while the Series 9 scores 12972. With the same processor, the second closest machine to the Spectre XT is the HP Envy 4 with a score of 9966. Clearly, the Spectre XT's Intel Core i5-3317U processor and 4GB of RAM is keeping pace with the Intel Core i7-3517U on the Series 9. Till now, the SSD speeds on the Series 9 was the best, but the 128GB SSD on the Spectre XT trounces that rather easily. This machine has the fastest SSD that we've tested on a commercial ultrabook.

The Spectre XT's lack of a dedicated graphics chip ensures that its lesser-priced sibling, the Envy 4-1002tx ends up with better overall performance scores. So much so that the Radeon HD 7670M on the Envy scores the best in graphics test among all ultrabooks we have tested. But we would not read much into that considering the major demographic considering an ultrabook would look for performance, slim form factor and specs that should ideally include a full-fledged SSD, with the graphics card being a secondary concern. The tested battery life of 187 minutes on the Spectre XT would be good enough for around 5 hours of real-world usage at work, but there is no running away from the fact that it is lesser than the best out there – Samsung



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Specifications

Processor: Intel Core i5-3317U @ 1.7GHz; **RAM:** 4GB; **Graphics:** Intel HD 4000; **Storage:** 128GB SSD; **Display:** 13.3-inch (1366 x 768); **Ports:** 2 USB, HDMI, card reader, LAN; **OS:** Windows 7 Home Premium

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Series 9 (246 min), HP Envy 4 (223 min) and the Dell XPS 14 (210 min).

While the display is a tad reflective, the brightness levels are rather good on the Spectre XT; so is the vividness of colour and sharpness of text. The black level test results pegged the scores in the top half. While the resolution is merely 1366 x 768 pixels, it's easily among the better ones we've tested. The Samsung Series 9 has the best display by far on current ultrabooks, with the Lenovo IdeaPad U410 not too far behind.

The Spectre XT's keyboard is excellent to work on, with precise feedback. The key size is very similar to MacBook's keyboard, and so is the overall layout. Unlike the concave keys that have become a fashion, this keyboard has flat key design.

While our experience with Beats Audio has been rather tepid, the speakers on the Spectre XT are rather good. The primary reason is there are four speakers, with the layout ensuring two upward firing and two down firing.

Why we keep comparing the Spectre XT to the Series 9 is largely because (a) The Series 9 is the best overall performing ultrabook and (b) We want to establish that for a lot less, you can get almost similar performance in a largely identical form factor. The HP Spectre XT is possibly the best ultrabook you can buy at the moment, if slimness, exquisite build and an SSD are critical aspects for you.

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